

How to Read the Bible

Without Making It Say What You Already Believe

James Bell

LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

*Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved,
a worker who has no need to be ashamed, rightly
handling the word of truth.*

— 2 Timothy 2:15

Introduction: The Nose of Wax

The medieval theologian Alan of Lille, writing in the twelfth century, left us a complaint that has only grown truer with time. Authority, he said, has a nose of wax. He meant that a sacred text can be bent to face whatever direction the interpreter prefers, turned this way for one argument and that way for another, until it points wherever the reader was already going. Eight hundred years later the nose is more pliable than ever, and the people doing the bending are mostly sure they are doing nothing of the kind.

This is the charge the skeptic brings, and we should let it land before we answer it, because half of it is true. The Bible, he says, means whatever you want it to mean. It blessed the slaveholder and it armed the abolitionist. It has been quoted to start wars and to end them, to silence women and to free them, to justify the king and to behead him. Point to any position a human being has ever held and someone has found a verse for it. So why, the skeptic asks, should I take seriously a book that says everything, which is to say nothing. And the honest answer is that he is not describing a flaw in the Bible. He is describing what we have done to it.

I have done it. I want to say that at the start, because this is not a book I get to write from above anyone. I have come to the text with my conclusion already in hand and found the text agreeing with me, every time, which should have been my first clue that something was wrong, because a book that only ever agrees with you is a mirror, not a window. I have preached my own preferences and called it exegesis. I have reached for the verse

that won the argument and skipped the chapter that would have complicated it. The skeptic thinks the church is naive about its book. The truth is worse. We are skilled at it. We have become expert at making the Bible say what we already believed before we opened it.

And the reason we cannot see ourselves doing it is the reason this whole platform exists. We read through lenses we never chose and cannot see, the political and national and therapeutic and individualist assumptions we absorbed from the air, and we mistake the lens for the text. We think we are simply reading. We are reading our age back to ourselves in the Bible's vocabulary. The first thing required of anyone who wants to read Scripture rightly is not a technique. It is the humbling admission that you have been reading it wrongly, on purpose, without knowing it, your whole life.

So this book is less a method than a retraining, and underneath the retraining, a repentance. It is the slow work of learning to read in a way that lets the text get a vote, that lets it say something you did not already think, that lets it, on occasion, tell you that you are wrong. Paul told Timothy to be a worker who rightly handles the word of truth, and the word he used carries the image of cutting a straight road through rough ground. There is a straight way through a text and there are a thousand crooked ones, and the crooked ones are always easier, because they bend toward where you wanted to end up. The goal of everything that follows is not to help you master the Bible. It is to put you in the way of being mastered by it. Those are opposite ambitions, and almost everything depends on knowing which one you came for.

Chapter One: The Verse on the Mug

Start with the smallest and most common act of violence we do to Scripture, so ordinary that we have stopped seeing it as anything at all. We take a single verse, lift it clean out of the paragraph it lived in, off the page and away from everything around it, and hang it on a wall or a mug or the bottom of a social media post as a freestanding word from God to me. It feels like honoring the Bible. It is closer to dismembering it.

Consider the most famous example, the one we have already met in another book. I know the plans I have for you, declares the Lord, plans for welfare and not for evil, to give you a future and a hope. It is everywhere, the graduation verse, the new-job verse, the private guarantee that my particular dreams are about to come true. And it is a letter to a defeated nation being told their captivity in Babylon will last seventy years and most of them will die there. The verse is true and the comfort is real, but it is the comfort of a God who keeps his people through a catastrophe that is not going to lift in their lifetime, which is nearly the opposite of the meaning we have stamped on it. We did not read the verse. We harvested it.

Or take the one on the athlete's eye-black, painted under the eyes before the game. I can do all things through him who strengthens me. We have made it a verse about winning, about achievement, about God as the strength behind my ambition. Read the two sentences before it and you find Paul in a prison cell explaining that he has learned to be content whether he is full or hungry, abased or abounding. The all things he can do through Christ is the thing the verse is never used for. It is the strength to have

nothing and still be at peace. We took a verse about contentment in scarcity and made it a verse about succeeding at everything, and we did it because we read the sentence and never the paragraph.

This is what proof-texting does, and the reason it is so seductive is precisely the reason it is so dangerous. A verse with no context can be made to say anything, because there is nothing left around it to argue back. The paragraph is inconvenient. The paragraph has a flow and a point and a situation, and all of that constrains what the words are allowed to mean. So we cut the verse free of its constraints and then marvel that it now agrees with us. D. A. Carson put the rule as memorably as anyone. A text without a context is a pretext for a proof text. We have built much of our popular Christianity on exactly that pretext, a scrapbook of detached sentences arranged to confirm what we already felt.

A verse lifted out of its paragraph will say anything you want, which is the whole reason we lift it. Context is not a technicality. It is the text's way of arguing back.

So the first discipline, the one that everything else is built on, is almost embarrassingly simple. Put the verse back. Read the paragraph it came from, and the chapter around the paragraph, and the book around the chapter. Ask what the sentence is doing in the argument it belongs to before you ask what it does for you. This will cost you some of your favorite verses, or at least some of your favorite uses of them, and that loss is the first evidence that you are starting to read honestly. The verses you have to give up were never speaking to you in the first place. You were speaking through them.

Chapter Two: One Story, Not Thirty Thousand Verses

The way we print the Bible has quietly taught us to misread it. Open almost any English Bible and the page is a grid of numbers, every sentence tagged, the whole book broken into chapters and the chapters into verses, and the effect of all that numbering is to make Scripture look like a list. A list of discrete, equal, detachable units, any one of which can be pulled out and held up on its own. We read it the way we read a reference book, by looking things up.

It was not written that way, and it did not look that way for most of its life. The chapter divisions we use were added by Stephen Langton, the archbishop of Canterbury, around the year 1227, more than a thousand years after the New Testament was finished. The verse numbers came later still, dropped in by a Paris printer named Robert Estienne in 1551, reportedly while traveling on horseback. They are useful. They let us find things and point others to what we found. But they are not Scripture, and they have done something to our minds that the original authors never intended. They have trained us to see thirty-one thousand verses where God gave us one story.

Because that is what the Bible actually is. Not an anthology of wise sayings, not a database of equal and independent truths, but a single sweeping story with a beginning and a shape and an end. It opens in a garden and closes in a city. It runs from creation through the fall, through the call of Abraham and the making of Israel, through exile and the long ache of promise, to the coming

of Christ, the birth of the church, and the new creation still ahead. N. T. Wright has taught a generation to read it as a drama in several acts, and the image is exactly right, because you cannot understand a line in the fourth act if you think it is the opening line of the play. You have to know where you are in the story to know what any sentence in it means.

Most of our worst misreadings are this one mistake wearing different clothes. We take a command God gave to Israel under the old covenant and apply it flat to ourselves, as though the cross never happened and the story never moved. We take a promise made to a specific people at a specific hinge of the drama and claim it as a private guarantee. We read a sentence from act two as if it were addressed directly to us in act five, skipping everything in between that would tell us how it has been fulfilled or transformed or carried forward. The verse is not wrong. We have just ripped it out of the only thing that gives it its meaning, which is its place in the one story God is telling.

The Bible is not a field of stones you pick through for the pretty ones. It is a single river, and a sentence means what it means by where it sits in the current.

To read well, then, is to read the whole before the part, and the part always in light of the whole. It is to keep asking where am I in the story, what has already happened, what has not happened yet, who is being spoken to and at what point in the drama. This is slower than looking up a verse, and far less convenient, and it is the difference between hearing what God said and hearing the echo of your own voice in a fragment. The Bible is a story before it is anything else. The person who forgets that will spend a lifetime quoting it accurately and understanding it not at all.

Chapter Three: Written For You, Not To You

The Bible was written for you, but it was not written to you. That distinction will save you from more errors than almost any other, and everything in this chapter hangs on it. Every word of it is for you, profitable, given by God for your instruction and your life. But not one word of it was originally addressed to you. Paul was not thinking of you when he asked Timothy to bring the cloak he left at Troas. The letter to the Corinthians was written to Corinthians, real people in a real port city with real problems you have never had, in a language you do not speak, inside a world that is not yours.

We skip this constantly, and the skipping is the source of endless trouble. We open the Bible and ask, before anything else, what does this mean to me. It sounds humble and devotional, and it is actually a kind of theft, because it makes me the center of a text that was about someone else first. The honest order is the reverse. First I have to ask what it meant to them, the people it was actually written to, in their situation, with their assumptions. Only after I have heard what it meant can I responsibly ask what it means now. Meaning runs from then to now. It does not start with now and reach back to conscript the past.

Take a verse nearly every church has on a wall. Where two or three are gathered in my name, there am I among them. We use it to comfort the small gathering, the prayer meeting where hardly anyone showed, the reassurance that Jesus is present even when the room is thin. A lovely thought, and not at all what the

sentence is doing. Read the paragraph and you find that Jesus is talking about church discipline, about the process for confronting a sinning brother, about the authority of the gathered church to bind and loose. The two or three are witnesses in a disciplinary matter. The verse is about the weight of the church's judgment, not the consolation of a poorly attended service. We did not mishear a word of it. We just never asked what it meant to the people it was said to, so we filled it with what we needed it to mean.

The work this asks of you is the work of a guest, not a host. You are entering someone else's house, an ancient house, and the first courtesy is to learn its customs before you rearrange its furniture. What did this word mean in that culture. What was the situation the author was addressing. What would the first hearers have understood, with their ears, in their world. A study Bible, a good commentary, ten minutes of learning the background, all of it is simply the labor of listening before speaking. It is slower than making the verse about yourself. It is also the only way to hear what God actually said instead of what you wished he had.

The most spiritual-sounding question, what does this mean to me, is often the most selfish one, because it makes me the author of a text I was supposed to receive. Ask first what it meant to them.

None of this puts the Bible at a distance from you. It does the opposite. The God who spoke to Corinthians about their divisions and to exiles about their captivity is speaking to you, but he is speaking through a real word he said to real people, and you will hear him more clearly, not less, when you stop making every verse a private message and start listening to the conversation it was actually part of. The Bible is for you

precisely because it was first to them. Honor the to, and the for
will open up beneath it, deeper and truer than the shortcut ever
was.

Chapter Four: A Psalm Is Not a Law

We say the Bible as if it were one book, and the grammar misleads us, because the Bible is not a book. It is a library. Sixty-six books written across roughly fifteen centuries by dozens of hands in at least three languages, and those books come in many different kinds of writing. There is narrative and there is law. There is poetry and there is proverb. There is prophecy, and gospel, and letter, and the strange coded visions we call apocalyptic. And this is where most readers come to grief. You do not read all of those the same way, any more than you read a love poem the way you read a tax form.

Genre is the set of instructions a piece of writing gives you about how to read it. When you pick up a newspaper you read the front page and the comics and the obituaries by completely different rules, automatically, without thinking, because you know what kind of writing each one is. The trouble in the Bible is that we often do not know, or do not stop to ask, and so we read poetry as if it were a science textbook and law as if it were a personal promise and vision as if it were a coded calendar of future events. The words are inspired. The reading is a category error. We are obeying the wrong instructions because we never checked which kind of writing we were holding.

The clearest casualty of this is the book of Proverbs, and the damage is pastoral, not just academic. A proverb is a piece of general wisdom, a statement of how life usually goes, not an ironclad promise of how it will always go in every case. Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old he will not depart from it. That is wisdom, profoundly true as a general

pattern, and it is not a contract. I have sat with godly, faithful parents who did everything right and watched a child walk away anyway, and who were then crushed a second time by a verse they had been taught to read as a guarantee, so that the child's rebellion felt like proof of their failure or God's. They were not failed by God. They were failed by a teacher who read a proverb as if it were a law. The genre was the whole issue, and no one told them.

Gordon Fee and Douglas Stuart wrote the standard book on this, and even its title is the lesson. *How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth*, and the worth, they argue, is only available to the reader who reads each genre as the thing it actually is. Read the narratives as narratives, which describe what happened and only sometimes prescribe what you should do. Read the poetry as poetry, full of image and exaggeration and feeling, not wooden literalism. Read the apocalyptic, the book of Revelation above all, as the wild symbolic literature it announced itself to be, not as a newspaper from the future written in advance. The first question to ask of any passage, before what does it mean, is what kind of writing is this. The kind tells you the rules. The rules keep you from forcing a poem to testify in a trial it was never called to.

A proverb is not a promise. A vision is not a calendar. A story of what someone did is not always a command to do it. Read the genre wrong and you will quote the Bible perfectly while completely misunderstanding it.

So learn the kinds. It is not hard, and it changes everything. A few hours spent learning how Hebrew poetry works, what wisdom literature is for, how prophecy functions, how the Gospels are built, will do more to protect you from misreading

than years of sincere but untrained devotion. The Bible came to us in many voices and many forms, and God chose those forms on purpose. To honor the Bible is to honor its genres, to read each book as the kind of book it is, and to stop demanding that a psalm behave like a statute. The text told you how to read it. Most of our errors are the sin of not listening.

Chapter Five: The Sense the Author Meant

There is a phrase that has slipped into the way Christians talk about Scripture, and it sounds so pious that we never examine it, and it is doing real damage. What this verse means to me. We say it in small groups and in sermons, each person offering what the text means to them, as though a passage were a stone that refracts a different color for every eye, and the meaning were something each reader generates rather than something the author put there. It feels humble, this refusal to claim the meaning. It is actually a quiet seizure of authority, because if meaning is whatever it means to me, then I am no longer reading the author. I am the author.

Against this stands a principle so basic it should not need defending, except that our age has made it controversial. A text cannot mean what it never meant. The words on the page were put there by someone who intended to communicate something specific, and our task as readers is to recover what he meant, not to manufacture something he never said. The Corinthians could not make Paul's letter mean the opposite of what Paul meant, and neither can we. The meaning is fixed at the author's end, in the past, in his intention, and reading is the humble work of crossing the distance to find it, not the proud work of filling the words with our own content and calling it insight.

Kevin Vanhoozer wrote a whole book defending this against a fashionable view that the author is dead and the reader makes the meaning, and he framed it, rightly, as a matter of ethics. To read

is to encounter another person through their words, and to read well is to do justice to that person, to attend to what they actually said rather than drowning them out with what I would prefer they had said. Interpretation is a moral act. There is a way of reading that loves the author enough to listen, and a way of reading that uses the author as a ventriloquist's dummy, and the difference between them is the difference between hearing God and hearing yourself in a holy accent.

This is also where the old guardrails come in, the ones the church developed precisely to keep us honest. Scripture interprets Scripture, the clear passages governing the obscure, so that you do not build a doctrine on one murky verse against the plain sense of a hundred others. The analogy of faith, which says no reading of one part can contradict the settled teaching of the whole. These are not cages on the text. They are the railings on the road, the accumulated wisdom of a community that learned the hard way how easily a clever reader can make a single verse say something the rest of the Bible flatly denies. The author had a sense. The whole book guards it. The reader's job is to find it, not to overrule it.

A text cannot mean what it never meant. The moment meaning becomes whatever it means to me, I have stopped reading and started writing, and signed God's name to my own work.

And do you see why this matters so much for the soul, and not just for the seminar. A meaning I generate can never correct me, because I made it, and a god who only ever says what I already think is an idol I have carved out of verses. But a text with a real, fixed, author-given sense can stand over me and tell me I am wrong. It can resist me. It can wound me and heal me, precisely

because it is not mine to control. The whole hope of reading the Bible is that there is Someone on the other end of the words who meant something, and that I can be changed by finding out what. Surrender the author's meaning and you have surrendered that hope. You are left alone in the room with your own reflection, mistaking it for the voice of God.

Chapter Six: With the Church, Not Just My Bible and Me

The Reformation put the Bible into the hands of ordinary people, and that was a glory, one of the great gifts in the history of the church. But somewhere along the way, especially in America, we added a clause the Reformers never wrote. We turned the Bible in every hand into the Bible alone in every hand, just me and my Bible and the Holy Spirit, with no one else in the room and no one else's reading allowed to matter. The Reformers taught sola scriptura, that Scripture is the final authority over the church. We slid it into something different, solo scriptura, that Scripture belongs to each individual to interpret privately, accountable to no one. Those are not the same doctrine. The second one is a recipe for chaos, and the chaos is all around us.

Look at the result and you cannot miss it. There are now well over thirty thousand Protestant denominations, and the number keeps climbing, each one in many cases born of someone certain that his private reading of the text was the obvious one and everyone else had simply failed to see it. The man with his Bible and his confidence and no tradition to answer to does not arrive at the plain truth. He arrives at his own reflection, and then he founds a church around it. The promise of solo scriptura was clarity. The fruit of it has been endless division, because a thousand sincere readers with no shared accountability will produce a thousand Bibles, each one bearing a striking resemblance to the reader who found it.

The cure is not to take the Bible out of your hands. It is to put

other people back in the room, and most of those people are dead. To read with the church across time, in the company of the great interpreters and the ancient creeds and what the early Christians called the rule of faith, the summary of the gospel that Irenaeus was already appealing to around the year 180 as the boundary of sound reading. These are not authorities over Scripture. They are guardrails beside it, the hard-won wisdom of two thousand years of people who prayed over these same words and who can keep my private cleverness from driving off a cliff that others have already gone over. Chesterton called tradition the democracy of the dead, the refusal to let the small arrogant aristocracy of those who merely happen to be alive right now cast the only votes. C. S. Lewis called the opposite error chronological snobbery, the unexamined assumption that the present is wiser than the past simply because it came later.

There is a humbling and very practical fact buried in all of this. That brilliant new reading you just discovered, the one you are sure no one has ever seen before, the verse that means something the whole church somehow missed, is almost certainly not a discovery. It is far more likely an error, and an old one, and the reason it has a name and a refutation already is that someone tried it centuries ago and the church examined it and found it wanting. Most heresies are not new. They are reruns. To read in the company of the saints who came before you is to inherit their hard lessons for free, instead of paying again, in person, for mistakes the church already made and survived.

The Spirit was given to the church, not to me alone on my couch. Reading with the communion of saints across the centuries is not a threat to my freedom. It is God's protection of me from myself.

So read your Bible, by all means, in your own hands, in your own language, daily and hungrily, as the Reformers fought and died to let you do. But do not read it alone. Read it with a good commentary open beside you, with the creeds in your memory, with the great teachers of the past as your companions and your check. When your reading lines up with how the faithful have understood the text for two thousand years, you can hold it with confidence. When your reading is brand new, and yours alone, and overturns what the whole church has always seen, the humble and statistically sound conclusion is not that you are a prophet. It is that you have made a mistake, and that the communion of saints is standing ready, as it always has, to help you find it.

Chapter Seven: Christ Is the Point

On the afternoon of the resurrection, two disciples walked the road to Emmaus in grief, and a stranger fell in beside them and asked why they were so downcast, and they poured out their disappointment about the prophet they had hoped would redeem Israel and who had instead been crucified. The stranger was Jesus, though they did not yet know it, and what he did next tells you how to read the whole Bible. And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he interpreted to them in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself. He took the entire Hebrew Scriptures, the only Bible they had, and he read all of it as being, in the end, about him.

This is the deepest principle of Christian reading, and it is the one most easily lost under all the others. The Bible is not a flat collection of moral lessons with a section about Jesus near the back. It is one story, and the story has a center, and the center is Christ. The Old Testament is not a separate religion that ends when the New begins. It is the long setup, the promise and the shadow and the ache, all of it leaning forward toward the One who fulfills it. To read the Bible without making it say what you want includes this, and it is the part we are most tempted to skip, because turning the Bible into a manual for self-improvement or a rulebook for good behavior or a program for our political side are all ways of making it about us, when it was always, first and finally, about him.

Watch how the failure works in practice, because it is everywhere. Take the story of David and Goliath, one of the most preached passages in the Bible. In the typical telling it

becomes a lesson about facing the giants in your life, your fears, your obstacles, your big scary problems, with a little faith and a few smooth stones. Tim Keller spent years pointing out what that reading quietly does. It puts you in the role of David, the hero, and reduces the living God to a motivational resource for your personal battles. But Israel could not fight Goliath. That was the whole point. They were helpless and terrified, and salvation came through an unlikely champion who fought in their place and won a victory they then shared in. The story is not mainly about your courage. It is about a substitute who saves a people who could not save themselves, which is to say it was always pointing past David to great David's greater Son. Make yourself the hero and you have not just missed Christ. You have replaced him.

Now, a caution, because this principle can be abused too. To say the whole Bible points to Christ is not to flatten every text into a strained allegory, to find a hidden Jesus under every rock and in every piece of furniture in the tabernacle, ignoring what the passage actually meant in its own place in the story. The honest reading holds both. It honors what a text meant to its first hearers, in its own moment in the drama, and it sees how that moment fits into the single story that finds its climax in Christ. Augustine, in his great handbook on reading Scripture, gave the test that keeps this from going wrong. Any interpretation that builds up love of God and neighbor is on the right road, and any reading that does not, however clever, has gone astray. The point of the whole book is a Person, and the Person is love made flesh, and reading that does not end there has missed the destination no matter how it admired the scenery.

If your reading of the Bible makes it mainly a book about you and your improvement, you have missed the

One it is mainly about. The hero of every page was never going to be you.

This is the reading that finally guards you against making the Bible say what you want, because it relentlessly de-centers you. A book about your success can be bent to flatter you. A book about your rules can be bent to condemn your enemies. But a book about Christ crucified and risen, read as the story of God rescuing a people who could not rescue themselves, keeps refusing to be about you, and in refusing, it does the one thing you actually needed. It takes your eyes off yourself and fixes them on him. You came looking for principles for your life. You were meant to find a Savior for it. That is the difference between using the Bible and being saved by the God who wrote it.

Chapter Eight: The Passages We Skip

An honest book about reading the Bible has to walk into the rooms we keep locked, the passages we hurry past, the texts that made me, when I was still an unbeliever, certain the whole thing was indefensible. The slaughter in the conquest of Canaan. The laws that read as cruel to modern ears. The psalms that pray for the death of enemies and the dashing of infants against rocks. The verses that have been used to bless slavery, to silence women, to justify a hundred horrors. We know these passages are there. Mostly we handle them by not handling them at all. And the two ways we usually do reach for them are both forms of dishonesty.

The first dishonest move is to weaponize them, to keep the hard texts loaded and use them as clubs, ripping a difficult verse out of its story and its genre and its place in the drama and swinging it at whoever we want to condemn. This is proof-texting turned violent, every error of the earlier chapters now aimed at a human being. The second dishonest move is the opposite, to explain them away, to pretend the troubling passages are not really there, to sand every hard edge off the Bible until it agrees entirely with the sensibilities of the educated present. The first treats the hard texts as ammunition. The second treats them as an embarrassment to be managed. Both refuse to actually read them.

The honest path is harder and slower and uses everything this book has been building. You read the hard passage in its context, in its genre, at its place in the one story. You ask what kind of

writing it is, whether it describes or commands, whether it belongs to a moment in the drama the story itself later moves beyond. Much of what horrifies us turns out to be narrative reporting what happened, not divine endorsement of it. Some of it is old-covenant accommodation that the trajectory of the story, climaxing in Christ, carries us past. And some of it, in the end, stays genuinely hard, and the honest reader sits in the difficulty rather than resolving it with a cheap answer, trusting the God revealed at the cross even where a particular text keeps its mystery. That is not weakness. That is the difference between faith and a slogan.

There is a lesson in the very fact that the Bible was quoted on both sides of the great moral fights, and it is the lesson of this whole book rather than an exception to it. In the American slavery debate, the defenders of slavery had their scattered proof-texts, isolated verses about servants obeying masters, lifted clean out of the sweep of Scripture. The abolitionists read the whole story, the exodus of slaves set free, the image of God stamped on every human being, the trajectory toward a kingdom where there is neither slave nor free, the heart of a God who hears the cry of the oppressed. One side proof-texted. The other side read the Bible. The question was never whether the Bible could be quoted for slavery. The question was who was reading it rightly, the whole story against the snippet, and history and Scripture together have rendered their verdict. The hard texts do not prove the skeptic's point. Handled honestly, they prove ours, that everything depends on how you read.

A faith that can only survive the verses it likes is not faith in the Bible. It is faith in a shorter book you have made by cutting out the parts that frightened you.

So do not skip the hard passages, and do not swing them, and do not file them down. Read them, all of them, with the same patient honesty you would want someone to bring to your own words on your worst day. Some will open up under careful reading and stop being hard at all. Some will remain difficult, and you will hold them with humility and an open question, which is a perfectly faithful thing to do. What you may not do, if you want to read the Bible honestly, is pretend the difficult parts are not there, or use them as weapons, or quietly edit them out. The God of the Bible is not afraid of your hardest question. The only thing he asks is that you actually read the book before you decide what it says.

Chapter Nine: Reading to Be Changed, Not to Win

Everything in this book has been about method, and method matters, but I have saved the most important thing for last, because without it all the method in the world will only make you a more sophisticated manipulator of the text. The deepest question in reading the Bible is not how. It is why. Why are you opening it at all. And the honest answer, for most of us most of the time, is some version of to win. To win an argument, to confirm what we already believed, to arm ourselves against the people we disagree with, to master the material. We come to the Bible to use it. And the Bible was never given to be used. It was given to use us.

James saw this with painful clarity and put it in an image you cannot shake. Be doers of the word, he wrote, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves. For if anyone is a hearer of the word and not a doer, he is like a man who looks intently at his natural face in a mirror, for he looks at himself and goes away and at once forgets what he was like. That is most of our Bible reading. We look intently, we even feel something, and then we close the book and within the hour have entirely forgotten what we saw, because we came to look and not to be changed. We treated the living word as information to be processed rather than a command to be obeyed, and information you can take or leave. The whole point of the mirror was that you do something about your face.

So the posture that makes all the method work is the posture of

obedience, of coming to the text ready to be told what to do and willing to do it, even when, especially when, it is not what you wanted to hear. The ancient church had a practice for this called *lectio divina*, a slow, prayerful, repeated reading meant not to extract a lesson but to be formed by the words, to read on your knees rather than at your desk. The aim was never mastery. The aim was surrender. You read until the text has read you, until it has named something in you that you had hidden even from yourself, and then you do not reach for an interpretation. You reach for repentance.

Because here, at the end, is the reversal that everything has been moving toward. You sit down to interpret the Bible, and if you read it rightly, long enough and honestly enough, you discover that it is interpreting you. The word of God is living and active, the writer of Hebrews says, sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing to the division of soul and of spirit, and discerning the thoughts and intentions of the heart. You came as the reader, the one in the chair, the one in control, holding the text and deciding what it means. And slowly the chair turns. You are the one being read. The thoughts and intentions of your heart, the very things you were trying to protect by making the Bible say what you wanted, are laid open by the book you thought you were examining.

You sit down to interpret the Bible and discover, if you are honest, that it is interpreting you. You came holding the text. It ends holding you.

This is why the goal was never to make the Bible say what you want, and why that whole ambition, which this book has tried to dismantle page by page, was always a way of running from the only thing reading Scripture is for. You do not want a Bible that

says what you want. A Bible that only ever agreed with you could never save you, never correct you, never tell you the one thing you most need and least want to hear. What you actually need, under all the self-protection, is to become the kind of person who can bear to hear what it really says, and then to do it. That is the whole of it. Stop trying to bend the nose of wax. Put down the verse you were going to win with. Open the book, and read it until it reads you, and let the God who wrote it finally say the thing you have spent your whole life arranging the words to avoid.